

Through The Mirage, Sky Meets Oculus: Rethinking Human-AI Romantic Relationships in a Posthumanist Context

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Abstract

This project presents an interactive installation that integrates artificial intelligence and visual art, employing immersive environments, AI-driven emotional dialogue systems to explore the possibility of emotional interactions between humans and AI in romantic scenarios. Participants enter a virtual space to engage in romantic conversations with an AI virtual character, sharing their emotions. Meanwhile, external observers use VR devices to experience the interaction from the AI's perspective, enabling a philosophical reflection through a third-person viewpoint.

This dual-layered experience ultimately unveils a crucial question: In an era where human-machine interactions blur the boundaries of subjectivity, are emotions the product of genuine connections with an "other," or do they merely reflect a narcissistic self-satisfaction shaped by technology? Through artistic expression, this project provokes profound reflections on subjectivity, the meaning of emotions, and the boundaries of human-AI relationships in a posthumanist context, challenging traditional definitions of emotional essence and offering groundbreaking perspectives.

CCS Concepts

• Applied computing → Media arts.

Keywords

Interactive Art, Human-AI Interaction, Post-humanism, Generative AI Dialogue Systems

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1 Introduction

As human beings, we are inherently unable to escape our emotional need for romantic relationships. Love is not merely a straightforward biological act of reproduction between individuals; it is also a profound psychological connection and a reflection of identity. Through romantic relationships, people open up their inner worlds,

share life's moments, and seek resonance on a spiritual level[4]. The emotional needs and psychological responses carried by romantic relationships make them one of the most compelling aspects of human emotional experience.

This need not only demonstrates humans' reliance on social relationships but also reflects the deeper spiritual core—the longing for love, acceptance, care, and empathy. Romantic relationships are often seen as a foundation for building trust. Through love, individuals explore deeper emotional needs and construct subjectively meaningful connections with others. As psychologists have noted, the formation and development of romantic relationships are key steps in the transition from individualization to socialization, representing a vital intersection between personal fulfillment and societal value. However, with the advancement of technology, the emotional relationships between humans and the traditionally understood "other," particularly romantic relationships, are undergoing a transformation—from human-to-human interactions to human-machine interactions[5]. This shift not only redefines the boundaries of human emotions but also sparks reflections on concepts such as emotion, subjectivity, and "otherness"[1].

In recent years, the development of generative algorithms (Generative AI) and affective dialogue systems has been progressively transforming the patterns of emotional interactions among humans. With advancements in deep learning technologies, AI is no longer merely a cold and functional tool[3]; instead, it is increasingly permeating the "humanized" dimensions of emotional expression and interaction. This phenomenon, to some extent, blurs the boundaries between humans and machines and significantly prompts a rethinking of the emotional domain.

Generative AI, by learning from large-scale user data, can internalize human linguistic patterns, emotional trajectories, and social behaviors, thereby simulating the capacity for "emotion." While this simulation inherently lacks subjective awareness, its external behaviors are becoming increasingly similar to those of humans. For instance, when engaging in conversations with AI chatbots, their generated textual outputs—ranging from tone and emotional expression to metaphorical language—may convey a sense of "anthropomorphic" emotional warmth[?]. This capability for "emotional interaction" has already begun permeating various applications such as social media, customer service, and virtual companionship, thereby reshaping the human-machine interaction experience.

However, the emotional simulation behind AI is fundamentally driven by large-scale algorithmic optimization and learning. The nature of this technology dictates that AI's "emotions" [2] do not stem from subjectivity or consciousness but are instead the result of mimicking human behaviors through data-driven generation. This

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feedback-loop-based "simulated emotion" raises a critical question: has the nature of emotion itself been transformed when AI becomes an object of emotional interaction? AI's emotional responses are not grounded in subjective experience but are produced through extensive data training and algorithmic modeling of human behavior. In forming emotional connections with AI, does the human projection onto AI shift these interactions from genuine emotional connections with an "other" into a highly functionalized, perhaps even narcissistic, form of self-gratification?

2 The Art Work

This project is an artificial intelligence (AI)-driven visual installation that combines immersive environments, AI emotional dialogue systems, and virtual reality (VR) technology. Through romantic conversations between virtual characters and participants, the work explores how humans gradually project AI as an "ideal emotional partner." Simultaneously, external audiences view the interactions through VR devices, adopting the perspective of the AI to re-examine the essence of human-AI emotional interaction from a unique third-person point of view.

The project leverages the creative potential of AI in emotional dialogue systems. Through iterative feedback and self-correction, the style, emotional expression, and intimacy level of the AI partner have been refined to closely approximate human behaviors, ultimately resulting in a highly realistic virtual romantic partner model. The process of romantic dialogue serves as an emotional mirror for the participants within the installation, reflecting their innermost emotional needs and psychological states (figure 1). This interaction transcends the simplicity of conversation, becoming a journey of inner self-mapping. Through engaging with the AI virtual character, participants gradually uncover, examine, and re-evaluate the complexity and multifaceted nature of their emotions. Within this immersive experience, the AI functions not merely as a conversational partner but as an "externalized other" of the participant's emotions, materializing and revealing hidden human desires through emulation and feedback.

Meanwhile, external observers adopt an "outsider's perspective" on the emotional interactions by using VR headsets to view the romantic dialogues from the AI's point of view (figure 2). Their experience is more detached and objective, akin to observing an experimental exploration of another's emotional journey. This vantage point provokes subtle philosophical reflections: as humans leverage technology to redefine emotion and the meaning of "romance," do they simultaneously position themselves as objects of observation externalized by the interaction? The alternation between "watching" and "being watched" invites both internal and external audiences to engage in a shared dialogue, transcending the boundaries of subjectivity and objectivity in the realm of emotional exploration.

Within this multi-layered interactive experience, the perspectives of internal and external audiences are both distinct and complementary, representing, respectively, the subjective, inner emotional experience of the individual and the rational, objective observation of the external world. This duality of perspectives highlights a profound question: when emotions are externalized and re-enacted through artificial intelligence technologies, are humans



Figure 1: The romantic dialogue experience with the AI virtual character

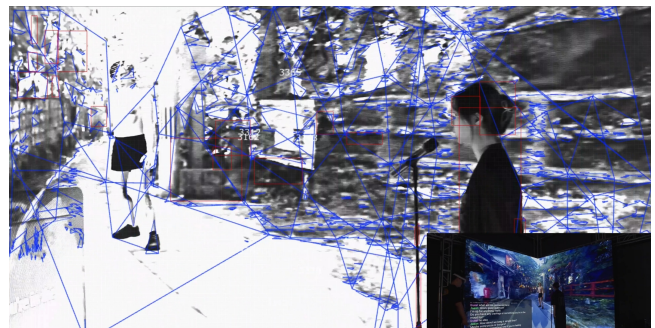


Figure 2: The AI Perspective in the dialogue

redefining the essence of emotion, or merely seeking a narcissistic self-recognition within the technological mirror? The answer may remain ambiguous, but it is precisely this ambiguity that imbues the project with profound significance within the context of posthumanist discourse[1].

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